

Continuous Improvement Program

Enterprise Guidebook

Prepared For:	Enterprise Strategy and Resource Management
Document Type:	Strategic & Operational Guidebook
Version:	1.0
Published:	July 1, 2026

How to Use This Guidebook

This Guidebook is the single source of truth for the Enterprise Continuous Improvement (CI) Program. It is designed to be utilized by all levels of the organization:

- **For Executive Leaders:** Focus on Part 1 (Strategy) and Part 9 (Maturity Model) to understand the program's value proposition, ROI metrics, and strategic alignment.
- **For the Innovation Roundtable & Steering Committee:** Utilize Part 2 (Governance) and Part 3 (Ownership & Triage) to guide decision-making, enforce tollgates, and assign project ownership.
- **For CI Practitioners & Champions:** Rely heavily on Part 4 (Methodologies), Part 6 (Execution Lifecycle), and Appendix A (DOWNTIME Matrix) for the tactical, step-by-step methodology required to execute a process improvement project.

Part 1: The Vision & Strategy

Within Enterprise Strategy and Resource Management, the Continuous Improvement (CI) program serves as the strategic engine for organizational modernization.

We exist to transition this organization from reactive, manual, and fragmented workflows to proactive, scalable, and data-driven service delivery. The CI program does not simply "cut red tape"; we are strategic partners and process architects who design how the agency operates effectively and efficiently to support the ultimate mission.

Strategic Alignment

Every project we undertake is directly mapped to the organization's overarching strategic goals. We do not pursue improvement for improvement's sake; we optimize processes to directly enhance mission readiness, reduce operational risk, and maximize resource utilization.

Part 2: Program Governance & The Innovation Roundtable

To ensure CI is institutionalized as a culture, a clear, multi-tiered governance framework is required to manage project intake, triage, and execution.

The Three Tiers of Governance

1. **Component/Directorate Level:** The first line of defense. Problems are identified and solved locally by CI Champions using basic Lean principles.
2. **The Innovation Roundtable:** An intermediate review board that triages complex, cross-functional issues that cannot be solved at the component level.
3. **The CI Program Office & Steering Committee:** The highest level of engagement, reserved for enterprise-wide, strategic transformation projects requiring significant resources.

The Innovation Roundtable Charter

The Innovation Roundtable bridges the gap between localized problem-solving and full-scale enterprise transformation.

- **Mission:** To triage process improvement requests, empower directorates to solve mid-tier problems collaboratively, and protect the CI Program Office's bandwidth for strategic initiatives.
- **Membership:** Comprised of designated CI Champions from each directorate, a representative from the CI Program Office, and key IT/Enterprise Architecture liaisons.
- **Meeting Cadence:** Bi-weekly (every two weeks).
- **Voting Rules:** Simple majority required to assign a project to a specific tier (Decision A, B, or C). The CI Program Office representative holds veto power if a project is deemed too technically risky for localized execution.
- **Submission Process:** All requests enter via the centralized "Front Door" intake portal and are reviewed by the CI Triage Desk prior to the bi-weekly meeting.
- **Performance KPIs:** Track the number of requests successfully resolved at Tier 1 and Tier 2 (avoiding escalation), and the cycle time from intake submission to Roundtable decision.

Enterprise Roles & RACI Matrix

Role	Definition & Responsibility
Executive Sponsor	A senior leader who owns the enterprise CI vision and provides strategic top-cover.
CI Steering Committee	A group of senior leaders that aligns CI initiatives with strategic goals and approves Tier 3 projects.
Innovation Roundtable	A cross-functional body of CI Champions and stakeholders that triages requests and manages Tier 2 projects.
Project Sponsor	The leader who owns the specific business process being improved. They are the ultimate decision-maker for their project.
Resource Manager (RM)	An independent financial stakeholder responsible for validating the ROI of projects.
Process Owner	The frontline manager responsible for day-to-day execution. They inherit the improved process and execute the Control Plan.
CI Team (Belts)	Dedicated CI practitioners who facilitate Tier 3 projects and train/mentor CI Champions.

RACI Matrix: CI Program Operations

Activity	Exec Sponsor	Steering Comm.	Innovation Roundtable	Project Sponsor	CI Team	Process Owner
Set CI Strategy & Goals	Accountable	Responsible	Informed	Informed	Consulted	Informed
Triage & Route Projects	Informed	Informed	Accountable	Consulted	Responsible	Informed
Execute Tier 1/2 Projects	Informed	Informed	Consulted	Accountable	Consulted	Responsible
Execute Tier 3 Projects	Informed	Informed	Informed	Accountable	Responsible	Consulted
Sustain Process Gains	Informed	Informed	Informed	Accountable	Consulted	Responsible

Part 3: Operational Ownership & The Triage Framework

Not every problem is a CI project. To avoid duplication of effort, we utilize an Operational Ownership Decision Model.

Workflow Ownership Decision Model

- **IT Service Management (ITSM):** Does the issue involve a broken system, a hardware failure, or a request for standard access?

Routing: IT Helpdesk (Incident/Problem/Change Management).

- **Enterprise Architecture (EA):** Does the request involve acquiring a net-new software platform or fundamentally altering the organization's enterprise data architecture?

Routing: Enterprise Architecture Board.

- **Continuous Improvement (CI):** Is the current process manual, inefficient, redundant, or requiring optimization of existing tools (e.g., SharePoint, Power Apps)?

Routing: CI Triage Desk / Innovation Roundtable.

The Intake Funnel & Weighted Scoring Matrix

1. **The Front Door:** All requests enter via a single SharePoint/Power Apps portal. Requesters must define the pain point and volume, not demand a specific IT solution.
2. **The Triage Desk:** The CI team scores requests against a standardized rubric.
3. **The Routing Decision:** The Roundtable makes one of three binding decisions based on the score:
 - Tier 1 (Self-Service): Return to Component.
 - Tier 2 (Targeted Assist): Accept into Roundtable Portfolio.
 - Tier 3 (Full CI Engagement): Escalate to CI Program Office.

The Weighted Scoring Matrix

Criteria	Weight	Score 1-2 (Low)	Score 3-4 (Medium)	Score 5 (High)
Mission Alignment	x3	Localized administrative preference.	Affects multiple departments.	Directly impacts core agency missions or audits.
Quantitative ROI	x3	Saves minimal time; marginal error reduction.	Saves 10+ hours a week; reduces rework loops.	Eliminates massive bottlenecks; automates data entry.
Compliance Risk	x2	No direct compliance impact.	Improves data accuracy.	Mitigates an active audit finding or vulnerability.
Technical Effort	x2	Requires massive IT overhauls.	Feasible within current setup.	Quick win; solvable with SOP or simple Power App.

Part 4: Core Methodologies & The CI Toolkit

- **Lean Six Sigma (LSS) & DMAIC:** We utilize the DMAIC cycle (Define, Measure, Analyze, Improve, Control). We apply Lean principles to eliminate waste and non-value-add steps, and Six Sigma to reduce variation and systemic errors.
- **Agile Delivery:** Rather than waiting months for a monolithic system rollout, we deploy iterative development sprints. We deliver quick wins, launch Proof of Concepts (PoCs), and adapt immediately to user feedback.
- **PDCA & Kaizen:** For continuous, incremental improvements, we employ the Plan-Do-Check-Act cycle and facilitate targeted Kaizen events to solve highly localized departmental issues.
- **BPM vs. BPR:** We distinguish between Business Process Management (BPM) to optimize and maintain existing operations, and Business Process Re-engineering (BPR) to fundamentally rebuild broken workflows from the ground up.

The CI Toolkit

- **Process Mapping & VSM:** Visually laying out every step of a workflow to expose bottlenecks.
- **SIPOC Matrices:** Defining Suppliers, Inputs, Process, Outputs, and Customers to establish clear project boundaries.
- **Root Cause Analysis:** Utilizing the "5 Whys" and fishbone diagrams to cure systemic issues rather than treating symptoms.

PRACTITIONER ADDENDUM: The CI Dictionary & "Zoom Level" Strategy

To operate effectively, all practitioners must standardize the use of the toolkit using the **Zoom Level Strategy** to prevent overlap and scope creep:

- **VOC (Voice of the Customer):** Proactively capturing the user's actual pain points, heavily utilizing Agile User Stories to define success parameters.
- **The SIPOC (30,000 ft. view):** A scoping boundary. It is NOT a detailed map. It sets the absolute start and stop points of a project.
- **Process Map / VSM (10,000 ft. view):** The visual flow of work. Calculates the ratio of Processing Time (PT) to Waiting Time (WT) to identify bottlenecks.
- **The SOP (Ground Level view):** The keystroke-by-keystroke instruction manual.

Part 5: Key Products & Services

When stakeholders engage the CI Program, they receive tangible, structured deliverables.

Documentation & Standardization

- **Process Guides & SOPs:** Comprehensive step-by-step guides for training and continuity.
- **"As-Is" & "To-Be" Blueprints:** Baseline assessments of current operations paired with engineered future-state architectures.

- **SLA/OLA Frameworks:** Structuring Service Level Agreements to define turnaround times.

Automation & Enterprise Deployments

- **Low-Code Workflow Automation:** Transitioning manual email routing into automated engines via Power Apps, Power Automate, and SharePoint.
- **Enterprise Service Deployment:** Digitizing priority mission support services into centralized platforms like ServiceNow.

Analytics & Knowledge Management

- **Advanced Data Analytics:** Translating process data into actionable intelligence through Power BI, Tableau, and SQL.

Part 6: The Master CI Execution Lifecycle (The Playbook)

All CI projects follow the rigorous DMAIC lifecycle. Progression between phases is mandated by Gated Tollgate Reviews, where the Project Sponsor must formally approve advancement.

Phase 1: Intake (DEFINE)

- **Goal:** Capture the Voice of the Customer (VOC) and establish rigid project boundaries.
- **Action:** Draft an Agile User Story to capture the VOC. Utilize the POCIS method for the SIPOC.
- **Tollgate Approver:** Project Sponsor

TACTICAL EXECUTION: Phase 1 Deep-Dive

1. **Agile User Story Formulation:** Frame the intake request strictly as: *"As a [User], I want to [Action], so that [Benefit]."*
2. **The POCIS Method:** Never complete a SIPOC left-to-right to avoid scope creep. Follow this order: **(P)**rocess (Max 5-7 steps) → **(O)**utputs → **(C)**ustomers → **(I)**nputs → **(S)**uppliers.
3. **The Golden Rule of Suppliers vs. Customers:** In a SIPOC, these are internal entities that shift roles. The *Customer* of Step 1 almost always becomes the *Supplier* of Step 2.

Phase 2: Discovery & As-Is Mapping (MEASURE & ANALYZE)

- **Goal:** Mathematically baseline the current state and hunt for the 8 Wastes of DOWNTIME.
- **Action:** Conduct a Gemba Walk. Draft the As-Is Process Map.
- **Key Insight (The "System Lane" Revelation):** Always include a swimlane for the IT System. If the human lanes are filled with manual "Data Entry" boxes while the System lane is empty, you have mathematically proven the need for Business Process Re-engineering (BPR).
- **Tollgate Approver:** Project Sponsor & Resource Manager

TACTICAL EXECUTION: Phase 2 Deep-Dive

1. The Micro-Capture Matrix: During the Gemba Walk, use an explicit grid to capture the Actor, Action, System, and Risk. Do not use a SIPOC for this micro-level data.

2. Visio Mapping Standards:

- **The Verb-Noun Rule:** Process boxes are limited to 5 words (e.g., "Submit SF-182 Form"). SOP details do not belong in the box.
- **Color-Coding:** Green (Value-Add), Yellow (Business Value-Add), Red (Non-Value-Add/Waste).
- **Customer Journey:** Map the user's emotion (frustration/neutrality) in a dedicated swimlane directly beneath the step causing the friction.
- **Waste Badges:** Apply DOWNTIME tags directly to Red shapes (e.g., [W] for Waiting).

Phase 3: Execution & To-Be Engineering (IMPROVE)

- **Goal:** Design the To-Be state and build the solution.
- **Action:** Perform Gap Analysis. Delete every Red/Waste-tagged box from the As-Is map. Draft the To-Be Process Map, replacing manual steps with automated system actions.
- **Tollgate Approver:** Project Sponsor (Steering Committee if capital is required)

TACTICAL EXECUTION: Phase 3 Deep-Dive

1. **Gap Analysis:** Compare the As-Is reality against the original Agile User Story. Every DOWNTIME tag represents a gap in efficiency.
2. **Erase & Replace:** Shift the burden from the human swimlanes directly into the System swimlane (e.g., replacing manual email handoffs with Power Automate routing).

Phases 4 & 5: Quality, Documentation & Closeout (CONTROL)

- **Goal:** Lock in the new standard and prevent regression.
- **Action:** Auto-generate the new SOP from the cleanly engineered To-Be process data. Execute the Hard Cut-Off (delete legacy PDF forms/network drives).
- **Tollgate Approver:** Project Sponsor & Process Owner

TACTICAL EXECUTION: Phase 4/5 Deep-Dive

1. **AI-Powered SOPs:** Because the Future State is captured in a structured grid (Actor, Action, System, Risk), practitioners feed this matrix into an AI tool (Copilot/Gemini) alongside the agency SOP template to auto-generate the keystroke instructions and format "Risks" into bolded Warning callouts.

Post-Project: Revalidation & Compendium

- **Process Library:** All final documents are housed centrally on OIGNET.
- **Revalidation:** Occurs 12 months post-completion to ensure the process map remains accurate.
- **Compendium:** A SharePoint list used to track all observations and recommendations generated from projects for continuous auditing.

Part 7: CI Team Roles & Onboarding

Our internal CI Team is structured by experience level to ensure quality control.

- **Gov. Program Manager:** Briefs leadership, oversees strategic direction, manages civilian onboarding.
- **Contract Team Lead:** Manages contract workload, executes special projects, conducts quality reviews.
- **Senior Analyst:** Leads high-level, complex projects; assists Team Lead with strategic initiatives.
- **Mid-Level Analyst:** Independently manages Business Process Mapping (BPM) projects.
- **Junior Analyst:** Focuses on process revalidation, project administration, and desktop guides.

Onboarding & Certification

New team members undergo a structured 3-week onboarding process. All team members are expected to maintain relevant professional certifications (Lean Six Sigma, PMP) and acquire continuous Professional Development Units (PDUs).

Part 8: CI Champions Network (Community of Practice)

The Formal Mandate

Champions serve as the operational vanguard—equipped to identify waste, document baseline processes, and foster a culture of efficiency—while bridging the gap between their local directorates and the Enterprise CI Program.

- **Core Responsibilities:** Draft As-Is process maps, identify the 8 wastes of Lean, and facilitate CI Intake requests for their peers.
- **Boundaries:** Champions do not build complex IT architectures or bypass the CI Intake funnel for major, cross-functional projects.
- **90-Day Soft Launch Strategy:** A pilot cohort of 5-8 selected staff will test the curriculum, mapping localized processes and escalating valid candidates to Tier 2/Tier 3 automations.

Part 9: Strategic Roadmap & Maturity Model

Our organizational goal is to achieve and sustain Level 3: Standardized (Managed) maturity, ensuring process improvement is a repeatable, audited, and enterprise-wide capability.

The CI Maturity Framework

Dimension	Level 1: Launch	Level 2: Emerging	Level 3: Standardized (Target)	Level 4: Integrated	Level 5: Optimized
Governance	Ad hoc top-cover.	Steering Committee formed.	Pipeline aligned to strategy.	Leaders measured on CI metrics.	CI embedded in strategic planning.
Execution Capability	Informal methods. External consultants.	DMAIC introduced. Internal CI team trained.	Tollgates enforced 100%. Tiered training deployed to staff.	Advanced data control. Internal certifications.	Continuous rapid experimentation. "Everyday problem solving" culture.

Level 3 Operational Targets (Metrics)

- **Strategic Alignment:** 100% of active projects map directly to an agency strategic pillar.
- **Sponsor Engagement:** >85% of tollgates formally signed off by the Project Sponsor.
- **Tollgate Compliance:** 100% of major projects complete all DMAIC phase reviews.
- **Financial Validation:** 100% of ROI/savings claims are independently validated by Resource Management.

Part 10: Case Studies & Real-World Impact

Spotlight: Workflow Re-engineering (DD254)

- **The Challenge:** The existing DD254 routing workflow was heavy, slow, and prone to version control issues and lost emails.
- **The Solution:** We mapped the As-Is state and engineered a hybrid architecture combining a Power Apps routing engine with a SharePoint document library for co-authoring. This transformed a manual paper chase into a seamless, trackable, automated lifecycle, drastically reducing rework loops.

Spotlight: Enterprise Alignment & Deployment

- **The Impact:** We successfully facilitated the deployment of 27 priority mission support services within ServiceNow, centralizing service offerings to hit critical fiscal year targets.

Part 11: Records Management & Retention Policy

Administrative Internal Control Management Records

This category covers records created to support the planning, implementation, and oversight of internal administrative controls. In accordance with NARA General Records Schedule (GRS) 5.7: Administrative Management and Oversight Records, Item 010.

- **Retention and Disposition:** Records covered under GRS 5.7, Item 010 must be destroyed 1 year after submission or when no longer needed, whichever is appropriate for operational use.
- **Disposition Authority:** DAA-GRS-2020-0001-0001

Appendix A: The DOWNTIME Reference Matrix

This matrix is utilized to identify operational waste. The First Question of CI is always: *"Are we executing this step because it adds tangible value to the mission, or simply because 'we have always done it this way'?"*

Letter	Waste Category	Definition	Real-World Agency Example
D	Defects	Work containing errors requiring rework.	Form submitted with missing signatures, triggering a 3-day email chain.
O	Overproduction	Creating more than needed, or too early.	Generating a 50-page weekly report leadership checks once a quarter.
W	Waiting	Idle time caused by system lag or approvals.	A critical document sitting in an inbox for 4 days waiting for clearance.
N	Non-Utilized Talent	Failing to use staff's critical thinking.	Analysts spending 15 hours a week doing manual copy-paste in Excel.
T	Transportation	Unnecessary movement of files or data.	Manually migrating files between different shared drives or SharePoint sites.
I	Inventory	Backlogs of work or hoarding information.	A massive backlog of 200 unreviewed intake requests.
M	Motion	Unnecessary physical or digital movement.	Clicking through 8 layers of nested folders to find an SOP template.
E	Extra-Processing	Adding more steps than the mission requires.	Having 4 managers review a routine request when policy requires 1.